

Room for Good Things to Run Wild

How Ordinary People Become Everyday Saints

Josh Nadeau

THE QUESTION

Why does knowing all the right things fail to change a person?

Because a person is a body and a soul together, and information reaches only half of them. Nadeau had a master's degree in what he believed and drank before work. What actually forms a person is what the body repeatedly does — so the failure was never a shortage of conviction. Nothing he believed had been practised into him, and the things he did practise were teaching him something else the whole time.

THE LITURGY OF THE EVERYDAY SAINT

The book is built in five acts, and each one closes with a short list of lines gathered from its chapters. The final pages collect all of them into one list the author calls a liturgy — not a summary to be read but something to be said and practised. The five acts are its movements, and each does a different job.

I The Anatomy of Anguish

Name what is actually wrong. Not weak willpower or insufficient belief, but a person cut in half, demanding a function from faculties he had already cut out.

II The Shape of Immanence

Be found rather than find. Grace was already waiting at the bottom, which means the first move was never yours to make and the question changes from how do I reach him to how do I let myself be reached.

III The Architecture of Incarnation

Build the life, don't just clear the ground. Putting sin to death without furnishing anything in its place leaves a swept, empty room, and something always moves in.

IV The Symphony of Embodiment

Practise the body into what the soul is meant to love. Goodness, truth and beauty are participated in rather than learned, and the body is how a person participates in anything.

V The Melody of New Beginnings

Go back to the ordinary. Nothing about the pattern required England or Spain, which is why the book ends at the same bank, the same alley and the same 5:30 in the morning.

INSIGHTS

01

Remove the Organ, Demand the Function

The diagnosis Nadeau borrows from C. S. Lewis is that we remove the organ and demand the function. He wanted to become good and had spent years cutting out the equipment goodness runs on — feeling, wonder, desire, and the body itself — then held himself in contempt for producing nothing.

Fear did most of the cutting, and not the trembling kind. It was a passive fear: too afraid to admit a weakness, ask a real question, or take responsibility for his own life. He describes the result as trying to walk without feet. In protecting himself he had removed what he needed in order to change.

This reframes almost every failure of self-improvement. Before asking why the discipline is not working, ask what faculty the discipline needs and whether it is still there. A man who has trained himself not to feel cannot be moved. A man who has traded wonder for explanation cannot be struck by anything. The demand is not the problem; the missing organ is.

02

Knowing Is Not Becoming

Information is not formation. Nadeau was catechized from childhood, holds a master's degree in his own faith, and wrote papers and sermons on the love of God — and could not say he had ever felt it. He knew every definition and none of it had landed anywhere below his skull.

He runs the ordinary version of this and it is hard to argue with. People who know lust is wrong are addicted to porn. People who know they should not be ruled by appetite take the extra slice anyway. People who know laziness is a corruption stay lazy. James pointed out that the demons believe, and it slows them down not at

all.

It means the correct answer, delivered correctly, can change nothing at all — which is why the pub conversation where a friend told him to pray more and drink less was accurate and useless in the same breath. Later he puts the mechanism plainly: we cannot be reasoned out of what we were never reasoned into. Nobody argued us into how we live.

03

A Ghost Is Not a Man

What he calls a functional Gnosticism ran under everything. Nobody in his church would say the material world is evil or the body a prison; everyone lived as though it were. The person was reduced to a soul, the soul to a mind, and the body left as a husk that carries the important part around.

A seminary classmate asked whether he was hungry, then answered that he was already feasting on the passage in front of him. A professor said the same thing without the smugness: scholars who never use their bodies in their work write about how to live with the blind spot still in. Chesterton's correction is that a corpse is not a man, and neither is a ghost.

It cuts both ways, which is what makes it lethal. If the body does not matter, poisoning it does not matter either, provided the numbing works. And if its appetites are suspect, tending the soul means denying every pleasure. Aislinn found the better sentence: every book says you are a few steps from the life you want, and you cannot take them, because you are not using your legs.

Emptying a House Is Not Furnishing It

He put down the bottle and apathy moved in. Then anger, then bitterness, then blame. Bitterness looks less sinister than being drunk before work and it unmakes a person just as efficiently, which is how he discovered that clearing a life out is only half of a job.

The tradition he came from was expert at the first half. Mortification is putting sin to death, and he had read four hundred pages on it. Vivification is meant to be the other half, bringing life in — and every time he pressed on what it actually meant, the answer turned back into the first half in different words. Two sides of a coin, same face on both.

Jesus draws it as a house: the unclean spirit leaves, wanders, finds no rest, comes home to a place swept and in order, and brings seven worse than itself. Nature abhors a vacuum. So the practical work is furnishing — a hearth, tables, chairs, art — and virtue is put on rather than vice merely put off. Pride is fought with humility, greed with generosity, anger with patience.

Desire Points Past the Pleasure

His second plan was apathy. Stop wanting anything and you cannot be discontent; cut the passions off at the source and nothing can hurt. He was sitting in a courtyard off Bay Street with a cigar when Steinbeck's line arrived: the sickness stays the same, only the symptoms change.

The passions do not die easily and do not go quietly. Mostly they pretend to be dead and come back as apathy, or as what he calls a duplicitous purity — the brittle claim that nothing here owns me. Poke that veneer long enough and it collapses, and the rubble is full of hidden rebellions. Apathy destroys the free and loving heart, which is the equipment contentment actually runs on.

So hunger is not the enemy; it matters what you feed it, and starvation is not an option. Lewis supplies the turn: a desire nothing in this world satisfies most likely means you were made for another one, and earthly pleasures were meant to arouse it rather than satisfy it. Nadeau had asked drink, success and relationships to bear an infinite load. They collapsed, and rage followed every collapse.

06

The Ordinary Is Holy

In a British café he looked under the table and found a stamp: made in England, roughly a hundred and fifty years earlier. What struck him was how used it was — how many elbows, how many glasses, how many conversations. It was marked by time, and that was the whole of its value.

Set against that is what he calls the myth of extraordinary. Success in every field has collapsed into celebrity, church included, and at a conference dinner he heard church leaders measure legacy in numbers, longevity and reach. His counter-example was John's famous friend, of whom the memorable thing was how little he thought of himself — leaving a room, he almost seemed able to fit under the door.

So: you will be forgotten, one generation or maybe three, and Nadeau means it as good news. Ordinary is not mediocre and not worthless; it is the frame we were built in. And a legacy is not optional — Steinbeck's version is that you pass something on whether or not you try, because leave a field fallow and weeds still grow. The only variable is what comes up.

ACTIONS

Audit the Liturgies You Already Have

Write down what you actually reach for in the first ten seconds of pain, boredom or loneliness. Then write what that act has been teaching you. The bourbon at 5:30 in the morning was teaching him, one repetition at a time, where salvation was kept.

Do it before adding anything new, because the schedule is already full. Everything repeated is formation whether or not anyone calls it that: the phone before your feet hit the floor, the scroll, the drink, the second screen. You are not choosing whether to be formed. You are choosing by what.

Resist grading yourself. The list is diagnostic, and treating it as a verdict is how he ended up trading drunkenness for apathy — a shell game with the same sickness underneath.

Practise the Virtue That Takes the Room

For each thing you are trying to stop, name the virtue that will occupy the space, then practise that instead. Pride is fought with humility, greed with generosity, lust with chastity, anger with patience, gluttony with temperance, envy with charity, laziness with diligence.

Learn it the way scales are learned rather than the way music theory is learned. The point is not to understand generosity; it is for the hands to know it, so that when the moment arrives the impulse is already there. That takes reps in real situations, which is why he calls discipline a form of freedom rather than its opposite.

One at a time. Seven virtues on a list is a list, not a practice, and the whole complaint of the book is against programs that promise the finished body in a weekend.

Give One Rhythm a Second Job

Take something you already do with your body every day and let it carry attention as well. His last chapter is the whole method in one page: thirty grams of coffee in a press, half a litre of water over it, six minutes to steep, and the Our Father said while it does.

Use the ones with waiting built in — the commute, the walk, the washing up, the sets between lifts. In Spain it was a mountain four mornings a week, which is where they talked and thought and got stronger at the same time. The body arrives at the thing before the mind can argue about it.

Don't add a rhythm you don't already have. He did not invent the hike or the coffee; he gave a second use to what his week contained anyway.

Get Under a Wing, Not Into a Program

Ask one person further along than you for ordinary time rather than curriculum. What he asked for, and got, was to see the inside of a life: beers at the York with Ben, a fireplace and a whiskey with John and Carrie, questions answered with stories rather than prescriptions.

The boxing club is the model. He got better because a coach watched him take the same left hook week after week, then showed him where his hand goes and how to tighten his feet. Heavy bags are one thing; it is different when the bag hits back. Nothing in his church life had ever hit back.

The person has to be able to see you, which means you have to be seeable. He spent one whole conversation hiding behind research he could cite instead of answering the question he had been asked.

Start Where You Are Actually Strong

Set the practice to the body you have. A shorter prayer. One psalm. One chapter of a gospel. Then let the threshold move. On the calisthenics bars by the Spanish beach some men ripped off thirty pull-ups and some managed one, and each of them was doing the only useful thing.

Formation is not competition, and comparison is the enemy of growth. He had a bad knee out of hockey and soccer and running, which meant physical therapy and tempered squats, and no amount of measuring himself against anyone changed that. The number that matters is your own last one.

Be suspicious of a routine sold as a program. The strong men know we look up to them, and a packaged regimen priced to our not-enoughness is the same salesmanship the book opens by refusing.

QUICK REFERENCE

THE QUESTION

Information reaches half a person.
Formation happens in the half it misses.

REMOVE THE ORGAN

Ask what faculty the discipline needs
before asking why it isn't working.

KNOWING IS NOT BECOMING

We cannot be reasoned out of what we
were never reasoned into.

A GHOST IS NOT A MAN

Whatever the body practises, the soul
eventually comes to believe.

FURNISH THE HOUSE

Clearing a vice out leaves a room, and
something always takes it.

DESIRE IS A SIGNPOST

Apathy is not purity. Hunger is not the
enemy; starvation is not an option.

THE ORDINARY IS HOLY

You will be forgotten. Ordinary is
neither mediocre nor worthless.

AUDIT FIRST

Name what you reach for in the first
ten seconds of pain.

PRACTISE LIKE SCALES

One virtue at a time, until the impulse
arrives before the decision.

A SECOND JOB

Give one rhythm you already have a
second use — commute, dishes,
coffee.

UNDER A WING

Ask for ordinary shared time, not
curriculum. Someone who sees your
guard drop.

YOUR OWN THRESHOLD

Formation is not competition. The
number that matters is your own last
one.

*Becoming a saint does not depend on place. It depends on
perspective and commitment — which is why the book ends at the
same bank, the same back alley and the same 5:30 in the morning
where it started.*